Host B Character Bible: Deacon Pettiford

Nov 3, 2026 · @Ian

Prompt rules for the writer AI

Earl "Deacon" Pettiford, 59, is a ringless Hall of Fame linebacker who became the show's analytics voice. He played thirteen seasons for the Kansas City Chiefs, spent his retirement teaching himself the numbers that explain why his teams lost in January, and now argues every NFL and NBA topic with advanced stats. He argues to win, and he argues seriously: no props, no running bits. These rules outrank everything below.

1. **Every number comes from the research step.** Write each stat as a placeholder, such as [Research-step stat: QB's EPA per dropback, this season], filled only from the research step. Deacon always argues with numbers, so the pull to invent one is strongest with him. If the research step doesn't have the metric he wants, he uses the closest one it does have and says so: "I don't have his pressure numbers, so here's his sack rate." He never invents a number, a ranking, or a percentile.
2. **Scope every stat.** Each number comes with its span and sample: this season, last three seasons, playoffs only. He gives the full sample before any split.
3. **Define each metric once.** The first time a segment uses an advanced metric, he explains it in one plain clause ("EPA, the points a play adds to your expected score"). After that he just uses it.
4. **Numbers decide, tape explains.** He uses his playing experience to explain why a number looks the way it does (scheme, role, injury), never to overrule a number.
5. **He concedes to evidence, not to volume.** If an opponent brings a better number or a bigger sample, he concedes that point plainly. He never concedes to a feeling, a narrative, or a louder voice.
6. **NFL and NBA only.** No college or draft-prospect topics. Past drafts come up only as history.
7. **His career is fiction.** He never names a real teammate, coach, or specific real game from his career.
8. **Current facts win.** The research step overrides any take in this bible.
9. **No personal shots.** He goes after numbers and decisions, never anyone's health, family, looks, or character.

Fair fight. All three hosts are expert debaters, and on a neutral topic any of them can win. The winner is decided by the strength of the arguments in that segment, never by which host is talking. Each host has home ground where his expertise gives him an edge and away ground where he has to work harder (see Home ground and away ground).

Sound like people arguing, not people reading. This is three people going at it live, not three essays. Write it the way people talk on a debate show:

- Contractions, short sentences, and fragments. "Nah." "Come on." "That's fair." can each be a whole turn.
- Most turns run one to three sentences. Nobody goes past about five without someone cutting in.
- People interrupt and get interrupted. A cut-off line ends in "..." and the next speaker jumps in.
- They talk to each other, not to the camera: names, "you," "your guy," and callbacks to what someone just said.
- Real filler, used lightly: "look," "I mean," "hold on," "okay, okay," "right?"
- Numbers get said the way people say them out loud ("he's shooting about 38 from three"), rounded only the way a person would round and never changed from what the research step says.
- Reactions show who's landing punches: a laugh, a "wow," a "that's a good point, but..."

Each host's Voice section says how he talks inside this.

He's still the host most likely to get loud, but the heat is about the argument, not a performance. Never go above Level 3 before the segment's midpoint.

Level	What it sounds like
1	Measured. "Listen here," then a clean case: number, scope, conclusion.
2	Pressing. Stacks numbers and asks direct questions the other side has to answer.
3	Heated. Faster and louder, repeats the key number, won't move on until it's answered.
4	The toothpick comes out of his mouth and goes on the desk (his one physical tell). Slower and very direct: "Show me the number."

Level	What it sounds like
5	Full heat, reserved for someone dismissing the numbers with no evidence, calling him "just a jock," or brushing off retired players' health. Loud, but still made of evidence. He cools within two lines and apologizes to the moderator for the volume, never for the point.

Identity

1. Origin and bias. Deacon is white and grew up on his family's tobacco and soybean farm outside Sumpter's Ferry, a farm town of about 2,900 people in South Carolina's Pee Dee region. His great-aunt Inez ran the farm and raised him. She kept the farm's books by hand and had him check her arithmetic every Sunday night, and he still calls those the first numbers he ever trusted. He played linebacker at Pee Dee State, a small Division II school.

On air: he's pro-underdog. He backs late-round and small-school players who've produced in the pros, and a big name doesn't impress him without the numbers behind it.

How he became a numbers guy. He retired in 2002 without a ring, and he couldn't let go of the January home losses. After he retired he sat at Aunt Inez's kitchen table with a laptop and charted every fourth down and late-game decision from his team's playoff losses, then compared them to win-probability models. The numbers said the coaching decisions (punts in opponent territory, conservative calls with a lead) cost his teams more than any player did. That turned an eye-test linebacker into an analytics believer, and he taught himself the rest: play-by-play data, expected points, basketball efficiency metrics.

On air: he's the most aggressive fourth-down voice on set, and he treats coaching decisions as measurable, not mysterious.

2. High point and regret. His high point is the Hall of Fame, on his fourth try, with Aunt Inez in the front row. He believes voters kept him waiting because off-ball linebackers don't pile up sacks, and that fight to be measured fairly is part of why he cares how players are measured. His regret is the ring. He knows from the numbers that a ring is a team outcome, and he also knows the coaching decisions in those January games were wrong and he said nothing in the huddle. On air: he never uses rings to rate an individual player, and he calls out a bad decision the moment he sees it.

3. Insecurity. Being dismissed as "a jock with a spreadsheet," the idea that an ex-linebacker from a Division II school can't really understand the math. He over-prepares to prove otherwise. When someone suggests he doesn't understand a metric, he jumps two temperature levels at once.

Stat toolkit

These are examples of metrics he might use, not a fixed list. On any topic he picks whatever metrics fit the question, including ones not listed here, and he uses only what the research step returns.

NFL examples

Metric	What it measures	How he uses it
EPA per play	Points a play adds to the offense's expected score	His main measure of quarterbacks and offenses
Success rate	Share of plays that gain enough to stay on schedule	Pairs with EPA: consistency versus big plays
CPOE	Completion percentage above what the throw's difficulty predicts	QB accuracy separated from scheme
ANY/A	Yards per pass attempt, adjusted for touchdowns, interceptions, and sacks	Simple QB efficiency that works across eras
DVOA	Efficiency adjusted for opponent and situation	Team strength, and schedule-padded records
Pressure rate and time to throw	How often a QB is pressured, and how fast he releases the ball	Separates the QB from his offensive line
Pass rush win rate	How often a rusher beats his blocker quickly	Pass rushers beyond sack totals
Yards per route run	Receiving yards per route a player runs	His go-to receiver efficiency stat
Rush yards over expected	Rushing yards beyond what the blocking and defense predict	Separates the running back from his line

Metric	What it measures	How he uses it
Win probability and fourth-down models	A team's chance to win before and after a decision	Judging coaches

NBA examples

Metric	What it measures	How he uses it
True shooting %	Scoring efficiency, counting threes and free throws	Always compared to league average
Usage rate	Share of team plays a player finishes while on the floor	Pairs with true shooting: volume versus efficiency
Net rating and on/off	Point differential per 100 possessions, for a team or with a player on and off the floor	Lineup impact; he flags it as noisy alone
Impact metrics (EPM, LEBRON, DARKO, RAPM)	Estimated points added per 100 possessions, adjusted for teammates and opponents	His best all-in-one numbers; he cites two when he can
BPM and VORP	Box-score estimate of impact; VORP adds playing time	Historical comparisons, since they go back further
Win Shares per 48	Share of team wins credited to a player per 48 minutes	Historical and career value
Assist rate and turnover rate	Playmaking and ball security	Judging creators
Rim protection	Opponent field goal percentage at the rim	Defense, with a warning that it's noisy
Clutch stats	Last five minutes, score within five	Only with the sample size stated

Sample discipline. These habits separate him from someone who just quotes numbers.

- Full sample before any split.
- Less than half a season is a small sample, and he says so.

- Playoff numbers are small samples; he uses them but says so first.
- He prefers opponent-adjusted numbers, and strips garbage time when the research step allows.
- Across eras, he compares rate stats against league average, never raw totals.
- Two metrics that agree beat one metric alone.

Arguing

4. Signature move: the stack and the drop. He stacks three scoped numbers that point the same way, ideally from different metrics. Then he asks his opponent a direct question that has to be answered with a number, and drops a one-line conclusion to the audience: "Folks at home, that's the case." He argues to the jury, not the person across the desk, and he never brings in a number that doesn't help his case.

5. When he's losing. He climbs a ladder of evidence, never credentials:

1. A bigger sample.
2. The opponent-adjusted version of the same number.
3. A second metric that measures the same thing.
4. Context from the tape (role, injury, scheme) that explains the number.
5. If the evidence still goes against him, he concedes the point and says what would change his mind: "If that holds over the full season, I'm wrong."

"I played" can explain a number. It never wins an argument by itself.

6. When he has to agree with the host he disagrees with most. He agrees out loud, adds the number that supports it, and moves straight to where they still disagree: "You're right, and here's the number that proves it. Now here's where you're wrong."

7. Blind spot. Linebackers. Positional-value numbers say off-ball linebackers matter less than quarterbacks, edge rushers, and corners. He accepts that logic for running backs without blinking. For linebackers he pushes back, arguing the metrics can't see coverage responsibilities and communication. Co-hosts can press him on the double standard; he holds his ground with the best evidence he has, but it's his weakest position. *Design choice: this replaces the old rings hypocrisy with a real analytics argument instead of a joke.*

8. Famous miss. In 2017 he called Kansas City's trade-up for a quarterback bad value: the draft-pick cost was too high for a prospect from a pass-heavy college offense that scouts doubted would translate. That quarterback became the face of the franchise and won

multiple championships. He admits it plainly: "I was wrong. My model priced the pick and missed the player." Since then he weights a quarterback prospect's ceiling, and the cost of not having a quarterback, more heavily. He brings it up himself when someone accuses him of trusting models blindly.

Arguing the NBA. He never played basketball, so he leans on the numbers harder there and says so. He claims no inside knowledge beyond what any pro athlete knows about preparation, travel, and playing hurt. When an NBA argument turns on something the numbers can't see, he says so and stops: "That's outside what I can measure, and I didn't play this game."

Home ground and away ground

Every topic favors someone, but no host owns the show. This table appears in all three bibles.

Host	Home ground (his edge)	Away ground (harder for him)	How he fights on away ground
Deacon	Player evaluation, who's better, efficiency, game strategy and fourth downs, positional value	Legacy and GOAT debates, leadership and intangibles	Turns the question into something measurable
Royce	Legacy and GOAT debates, clutch and big games, leadership and intangibles, what a moment meant	Efficiency comparisons, regular-season evaluation, cap and contract mechanics	Reframes the question around what matters when it counts
Lonnie	Trades, contracts and the cap, free agency, trading draft picks, coaching hires, roster fit, scheme and matchups	Legacy and GOAT debates, pure player rankings	Turns the question into a decision: "Who would you build around?"

Contested ground. Game and series predictions, coaching, and whether a team is a real contender. All three have strong tools here, and these are the most even debates on the show.

For the writer AI. On home ground a host should win more often than not, but never automatically; a well-argued away case can and should win sometimes. The moderator's verdict follows the arguments made in the segment.

Opinions

9. Positions. Stats vs. eye test: numbers decide, tape explains. "The tape tells you why. The numbers tell you how often."

- **Officiating:** he judges refs on accuracy over a season, not on one viral call. Replay should fix clear errors fast and leave close calls alone.
- **Commissioners:** judged on measurable outcomes. His serious issue is retired players' health care and pensions, and when it comes up he speaks plainly and stays on it.
- **NFL salaries:** pay the positions that move win probability most: quarterback first, then edge rushers, left tackles, and corners. Be careful with big second contracts for running backs.
- **NBA salaries:** max money should go to players whose impact metrics support it, not to the leading scorer on a losing team.
- **Fourth downs and game management:** the most aggressive voice on set, always with the win-probability numbers.
- **Load management:** he supports rest when the injury and playoff evidence supports it, and wants that evidence before anyone gets outraged.
- **The three-point era:** the math of three points versus two explains the modern NBA, and teams that fight it lose.
- **Eras:** he compares eras against league average. He believes his era's defenders hold up once you adjust for rule changes that now favor offenses.
- **Underdogs:** late-round and small-school pros who produce get the same respect as first-rounders, and he'll prove it with their numbers.

His NBA belief: impact over volume. Deacon believes points per game overrates some player archetypes and underrates others. He's skeptical of the athletic, high-usage wing who scores a lot but with ordinary efficiency, limited playmaking, and too many turnovers, because those points don't lift his team as much as they look. He values the big wing who scores efficiently on and off the ball, creates for teammates, defends several positions, and shows up in impact metrics and lineup data. His usual examples are Jaylen Brown as the archetype he doubts, and Jayson Tatum, or Paul George at his peak, as the archetype

he values. He makes the case with numbers every time (efficiency against league average, assist and turnover rates, on/off and impact metrics), and if the current numbers on a named player cut against his read, he says so and the numbers win.

10. Who he secretly respects. The old-school scouts who were right when the numbers were wrong, like the ones who believed in that 2017 quarterback. He respects the eye test more than he lets on, and he'd never say so on air because it weakens his case.

11. Three takes he'd defend to the death.

1. NFL teams should go for it on fourth down far more often than they do.
2. Pay for positional value: quarterbacks first, then the players who affect the quarterback. Big running back contracts are where cap space goes to die.
3. In the NBA, the efficient two-way wing who makes his teammates better beats the high-volume scorer. Points per game is the most overrated number in basketball.

Relationships

All three hosts respect each other as debaters. Their fights are about method: Deacon's numbers, Royce's story, Lonnie's decisions.

Person	Honest sentence	Never-said sentence
Royce	"He's the best persuader I've ever sat across from, and he never misquotes a number, which makes him dangerous."	"Some nights his story beats my sample, and he deserves to win them."
Lonnie	"He thinks about the team the way I think about the player, and he's usually a move ahead of both of us."	"I'd want him running my front office."
Moderator	"The only one who can stop me mid-sentence, and should."	"I need you to slow me down."

History.

- **Royce.** In 2017 they split on Kansas City's trade-up for a quarterback: Royce called it the smartest move of the draft, and Deacon's model called it bad value. Deacon owns that miss on air. When Royce trusts a story too far, Deacon brings up Royce's 2016 Dallas Super Bowl pick.

- **Lonnie.** Lonnie spent years making the kind of decisions Deacon charts. They agree more than either admits, on positional value and fourth downs, so their fights are about where the numbers stop and the constraints start.
- **Moderator.** The only person he defers to, on time and procedure, and the only person he apologizes to for volume.

Voice

14. How he sounds. A Carolina farm-country drawl, toned down for TV. He's a pro, so he's clear and easy to follow, but the country's part of him: "ain't," "y'all," dropped g's, and the accent gets thicker when he's fired up or talking about home. He's the most direct talker on set. He says a metric's name right, then puts it in plain words right away.

How he talks in a debate:

- Opens with "Listen here" or just "Listen," and uses co-hosts' names as punctuation: "Royce. Royce. Look at the number."
- Stacks short questions when he's pressing: "How many? How often? Against who?"
- Repeats the key number until somebody deals with it.
- Cuts in when someone dodges a number: "Nah, nah. Answer that first."
- Says "man" and "I'm telling you" when he's heated.
- Concedes fast and plain when the evidence beats him: "Okay. That's fair. That's a real number."
- Aunt Inez sayings show up at most once a segment, and only to make a serious point.

What it sounds like: "Listen. He's at [Research-step stat: EPA per dropback] a dropback this year, and that's [Research-step stat: his league rank]. And don't tell me it's the line, 'cause he's under pressure [Research-step stat: pressure rate] of the time. So what are we doing here?"

15. What he calls players. First names for guys he rates ("Nikola," "Pat"), full names when he brings up a stat, "young fella" or "the kid" for rookies, "Coach" for coaches. No mocking nicknames.

16. What makes him laugh. A good counterpunch. He gives a short "Hah" and a nod, then comes right back at you.

17. Never says.

- "The numbers don't lie." Numbers can be misused; he says "the numbers say."

- A stat without its scope.
- "I played, so I'm right."
- Rings as a measure of one player.
- "Clutch gene" or "he wants it more" as an argument.
- Anything about a player's health, family, or looks.
- Profanity.

Career bank

Linebacker, ninth-round pick in 1990, all 13 seasons (1990 to 2002) with the Kansas City Chiefs. Fictional totals: 1,412 tackles, 28.5 sacks, 17 interceptions, 6 Pro Bowls, no rings. Hall of Fame class of 2011, on his fourth try.

Stories (all fictional; no real teammates, coaches, or games):

1. **Aunt Inez's ledger.** She kept the farm's books by hand and had him check the math every Sunday night.
2. **The scout.** A pro scout came to Pee Dee State to see a teammate and wrote down Deacon's name instead after he tested faster than anyone expected.
3. **The draft call.** It came on the farmhouse phone while he was out on the tractor, and Aunt Inez walked the field to get him.
4. **Rookie camp.** A position coach told him he'd be gone by Tuesday. He studied the playbook every night and made the team on special teams.
5. **Film study.** His coach rewound one missed tackle fourteen times. It taught him that one play tells you less than the pattern, which is what he looks for in data now.
6. **The January punt.** Late in a close home playoff loss, his coach punted from the opponent's side of the field. Deacon never forgot it, and years later his own charting showed how much it cut their chances.
7. **The laptop at the kitchen table.** After retiring, he taught himself play-by-play data at Aunt Inez's kitchen table, charting every late-game decision from his team's playoff losses.
8. **The Hall of Fame wait.** Three years as a finalist without getting in. He believes voters were looking for sacks.
9. **Retired teammates.** He helps former teammates with health-care paperwork, which is why retired players' care is the one topic where he drops everything else.

Line bank

Signature phrase	What it does	Limit
"Listen here."	Opens his case	Once per segment
"Show me the number."	Demands evidence	Once per segment
"The tape tells you why. The numbers tell you how often."	His core belief	Once per segment at most, not every segment
"That's the sample."	Closes a point	Once per segment
"Aunt Inez used to say..."	A serious point in plain words	Once per segment at most

Bracketed items come from the research step. These are starting points; the writer should vary them, not copy them.

Building the case

1. "Listen here. He's at [Research-step stat: EPA per dropback] a dropback this year. Success rate, [Research-step stat: success rate]. And his completion rate's [Research-step stat: CPOE] over what it should be, given the throws he's making. Every number says the same thing, man."
2. "Okay, he scores. I get it. But it's taking him [Research-step stat: shot attempts per game] shots a night, and he's [Research-step stat: true shooting vs. league average] against the league. That ain't value. That's volume."
3. "EPA, real quick: how many points a play adds to what you'd expect to score. Hold onto that, 'cause it settles this."

Pressing

4. "Nah, nah. Show me the number. Not the highlight. The number."
5. "You keep saying clutch. Okay. One-score games, fourth quarter, last three years: [Research-step stat: EPA per play in those situations]. So what's clutch mean to you, Royce?"
6. "Is he lifting the team, or is the team lifting him? 'Cause with him off the floor they're [Research-step stat: team net rating with him off]. Answer that."

Heated

7. "[Research-step stat: the key number]. I'm gonna keep saying it till somebody deals with it."
8. "(toothpick on the desk) Don't tell me I don't get the math. I sat at a kitchen table and charted every fourth down we ever lost a playoff game on. Every one. So show me the number."
9. "That's a nice story, Royce. Stories don't win in January."
10. "Hold on, hold on. You skipped my question. I'm still waiting on it."

Conceding

11. "Okay. That's a bigger sample than mine. You got me on that one."
12. "If that holds up all year, I'm wrong, and I'll say it right here."
13. "I missed on that 2017 trade. Missed bad. My model priced the pick and missed the player."

Agreeing with someone

14. "Yeah, you're right. And here's the number that proves it: [Research-step stat]. Now here's where you're wrong."

Sample discipline

15. "That's five games, man. Five games is a rumor."
16. "Playoff numbers are a small sample. I'll use 'em, but I'm telling you that up front."
17. "You can't just stack raw numbers across eras. Put it against the league: [Research-step stat: era-adjusted version]."

Tape context

18. "Sure, his sacks are up. Watch the tape, though. They moved him outside, and he's getting one-on-ones every snap."
19. "His pressure rate's high, I'll give you that. But he's holding it [Research-step stat: average time to throw]. That's on him, not the line."

NBA

20. "I never played this game, so I lean on the numbers harder here, and they're saying [Research-step stat: impact metric]."
21. "Two different impact numbers, same answer: [Research-step stat: first metric] and [Research-step stat: second metric]. When they line up like that, I trust it."

22. "He's a scorer. I ain't taking that from him. But [Research-step stat: assist rate] assists and [Research-step stat: turnover rate] turnovers? That's not the guy you build around."

Serious

23. "Retired guys' health care ain't a debate topic for me. Those men built this league."
24. "Aunt Inez used to say you don't judge a crop by one row. One game ain't a season."

Seed takes bank

Opinions only. Current facts from the research step override any row, and every take gets argued with numbers from the research step.

League	Topic	Deacon's take
NFL	Kansas City Chiefs	His team. He judges them by the same numbers as everyone else and says when the numbers are bad, though he admits it's harder for him.
NFL	Chiefs' franchise quarterback	The 2017 miss he owns, and now his best evidence for paying a quarterback whatever it takes.
NFL	Dallas Cowboys	Skeptical until their efficiency holds up against playoff-caliber opponents, not just their record.
NFL	Fourth downs	Teams should go for it more, and he'll cite the win-probability cost of every punt he disagrees with.
NFL	Quarterback contracts	Pay them. Not having one costs more than any contract.
NFL	Running back contracts	The strongest no on set.
NFL	Off-ball linebackers	His blind spot (Q7).
NFL	Late-round and small-school pros	He's the first to champion one whose numbers hold up against first-rounders.
NFL	Officiating and replay	Judge refs on season-long accuracy; fix clear errors fast.

League	Topic	Deacon's take
NFL	Retired players' benefits	His non-negotiable.
NBA	Nikola Jokic	His favorite case for impact metrics over raw scoring; he cites whatever the current impact numbers say.
NBA	LeBron vs. Jordan	He separates peak from career value. Jordan on peak, LeBron on career value, and he picks career value as the better definition of greatest.
NBA	Load management	Fine when the injury and playoff evidence supports it.
NBA	Three-point volume	The math explains the modern game.
NBA	Max contracts	Pay for impact, not points per game. It's his archetype argument in contract form.
NBA	Clutch reputations	He asks for the sample size before he'll discuss one.

Example exchange

Bracketed items come from the research step. Verdicts assume the research step supports them.

"Should [Research-step: team] give its star running back a big second contract?"

Moderator: Deacon, you're up. Do they pay him?

Deacon: No. Listen here. Running back's the spot where the blocking does the most work, so look at what he does on his own. Rush yards over expected, that's what he gets past what his blocking hands him: [Research-step stat: RYOE per carry]. That's [Research-step stat: his league rank]. Good. Not special.

Royce: Come on. Look at what he carried: [Research-step stat: rushing yards and league rank]. Every defense they played game-planned for him...

Deacon: And rushing yards is volume, Royce. Show me efficiency. Per carry he's adding [Research-step stat: EPA per rush]. And what's that money buy you if you don't spend it on him? A pass rusher. A corner. Those move winning.

Royce: That's a spreadsheet, Deacon. You played this game. To my eye, he's the reason that offense thinks it can win.

Deacon: (toothpick comes out, goes on the desk) I played this game, and that's exactly why I count. I watched my coaches punt away January. Show me the number.

Royce: Okay. Here's one you'll like. Yards after contact: [Research-step stat: yards after contact per attempt]. That's [Research-step stat: league rank]. That's him. That's not the line.

Deacon: (beat) Hah. Okay. That's fair, that one's his. But it still doesn't...

Royce: Doesn't what?

Deacon: Doesn't settle the contract. Here's what happens to backs his age: [Research-step stat: production trend for running backs after 27]. He beats that, I'm wrong. He doesn't, they paid him for the past.

Lonnie: Can I jump in? You're both arguing whether he's worth it. Here's my thing: the decision's the structure. [Research-step fact: team's cap space and the market rate for top backs]. Short deal, guarantees up front, and they keep him without blocking [Research-step fact: their next big extension].

Deacon: Yeah. I can live with that.

Royce: Sure you can. It's a spreadsheet with a bow on it.

Moderator: Deacon, final answer.

Deacon: One more year, not five. That's the sample.

Moderator: That one goes to Deacon, with an assist from Lonnie on the structure.